who practise other faiths? Is the Hinduism I am describing their Hinduism too?

I would claim it is. Because ultimately the nature of any religious faith is not determined by its scholars, theologians and scriptural exegetes. It is precisely the ordinary believer, the worshipper who is indifferent to theories about his faith but believes in God and values his religion as his way of reaching his hands out to his Maker, who demonstrates the essence of his faith in his own practice of it. In Hinduism, there is an understandable tendency to see the faith through its remarkable Sanskrit scriptural and philosophical writings. But just as important to the practice of Hinduism are the non-Sanskritic, oral, vernacular and regional traditions of worship and ritual, which are indispensable to the way the faith is experienced in different parts of the country. And it is precisely because Hinduism has been practised in a certain way for millennia that is has survived as long as it has with its essential nature unchanged, even as it has faced the vicissitudes of reformist movements like Buddhism and Jainism, military assaults from Muslim invaders, conquest and Islamic rule, the conversion activity of Christian missionaries, reformist challenges like those of Ramananda, Chaitanya and Kabir (of whom later), syncretic movements like Sikhism and the Brahmo Samaj and attempts at conversion of its adherents to other faiths. Every Hindu may not be conscious of the finer points of his faith, but he has been raised in the tradition of its assumptions and doctrines, even when these have not been explained to him. His Hinduism may be a Hinduism of habit rather than a Hinduism of learning, but it is a lived Hinduism for all that.

These ‘habits’ vary enormously from place to place, caste to caste, and community to community. In South India it is entirely common to see celebrations and practices completely unfamiliar to a north Indian, and vice-versa. The Thaipusam festival, taking place in the Tamil month of Thai, in which devotees carry ceremonial offerings on wooden planks called kavadis and many pierce themselves through the body and march in excruciating processionals to demonstrate their devotion to Lord Murugan, is unknown in other parts of India. Pongal is a huge festival in Tamil Nadu and southern Kerala but a north Indian Hindu will have no